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The New Global Universities: Reinventing Education in the 21st Century by Bryan Penprase and Noah Pickus (review)

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The Review of Higher Education, Volume 48, Number 3, Spring 2025, pp. 513-514 (Review)

Published by Johns Hopkins University Press
DOI: https://doi.org/10.1353/rhe.2025.a954244

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The Review of Higher Education
Volume 48, No. 3, pp. 513–517
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Book Reviews

Bryan Penprase and Noah Pickus. *The New Global Universities: Reinventing Education in the 21st Century.* Princeton University Press, 2024; 352 pp. ISBN: 9780691231495

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In an era of rapid global transformation, higher education institutions (HEIs) must continually adapt to prepare students for a globally connected world. In *The New Global Universities: Reinventing Education in the 21st Century*, Bryan Penprase and Noah Pickus examine the birth, growth, and innovative approaches of a burgeoning wave of "start-up universities" reshaping global higher education. Drawing on the experience of their active participation in founding Yale-National University of Singapore (NUS) College in Singapore and Duke Kunshan University in China, the authors offer a distinctive voice on the positive features and potential challenges of creating a new university in a cross-cultural context. Penprase and Pickus introduce the concept of start-up universities as dynamic, entrepreneurial institutions that embody "youthful energy, utopian spirit, and open-ended possibilities" (p. 7). By embracing experimentation, adaptability, and innovation, the authors argue that these institutions present innovative solutions to the traditional educational model's challenges.

The book's contributions to conversations about the future of HEIs are substantial. The authors argue that the global start-up universities are navigating their ways through local educational mazes by combining cultural awareness, local knowledge, and strategic networking. Penprase and Pickus provide a rich narrative about how these institutions have managed to handle the complexities of global and local education systems while fostering innovative academic environments. The universities' strategic networking involves forming partnerships with other educational institutions, industry leaders, and local communities to provide students with a comprehensive learning experience. For instance, Fulbright University Vietnam successfully balanced autonomy with governmental oversight to secure both local support and institutional independence (p. 109) and the African Leadership University in Mauritius tailored its programs to meet the specific needs of the African continent (p.170). The latter's move from relying primarily on foreign teaching resources to fostering more profound connections with local communities was significant. It aligned with Knight and de Wit's (2018) concept of "internationalization at home" and reflects a critical development in the evolution of higher education internationalization.

According to the authors, start-up universities differ from traditional ones in their risk-taking and entrepreneurial leadership. The founders of these institutions are portrayed as visionaries who embrace uncertainty, take calculated risks, and are unafraid to navigate complex political and cultural landscapes. The emphasis of the entrepreneurial leadership, the authors argue, is a key factor in the success of these institutions, particularly when building from scratch in unfamiliar environments. The start-up universities are much like tech start-ups; they are not constrained by legacy systems, allowing them to operate with flexibly and focus on new approaches to curriculum design, governance, and student engagement approaches. The authors assert that these universities operate as "laboratories for innovation," where educational practices can be continuously tested and refined (p. 12).

One of the defining characteristics of these universities' identities is the commitment to training global citizens. The authors note the benefits of

interdisciplinary learning, project-based education, and partnerships with industry and other universities employed by these institutions. For instance, Ashesi University in Ghana is designed not only to educate students in technical skills but to nurture ethical leadership and a commitment to social responsibility. Ashesi's mission of training "ethical entrepreneurial leaders for Africa" exemplifies how start up focused on creating graduates who are deeply engaged with both their local communities and larger global challenges (p. 157). Similarly, Yale-NUS College in Singapore integrates liberal arts traditions from both East and West. Central to its mission, an intercultural curriculum encourages students to think critically and contribute to an interconnected world. By blending Western liberal arts education with Asian values and educational practices, Yale-NUS provides a model for institutions to create globally minded graduates to face global challenges.

These cases paint a positive picture of how start-up universities lead the charge toward a new educational paradigm, yet only examine part of the picture. For example, do they truly make higher education accessible to students from diverse socioeconomic backgrounds? The universities profiled in the book tend to serve relatively privileged populations and whether these models can promote social justice in higher education institutions remains underexplored. While the authors acknowledge the financial and regulatory pressures faced by start-up universities, a more critical engagement with the issue of equity and access is necessary if these institutions are to serve as truly sustainable alternatives or embrace to traditional universities.

The authors' focus on the pivotal role of faculty in determining the quality and success of these institutions is significant contribution. Penprase and Pickus detail how the universities emphasize hiring faculty with international experience who are also sensitive to local cultural contexts. NYU Abu Dhabi's hiring, for example, explicitly targeted professors who possessed a global outlook and, at the same time, were sensitive to the local culture. This approach illustrated the institution's ethos of promoting international inclinations and its continuous growth in the UAE. While this focus on faculty recruitment is commendable, the book could benefit from a more critical analysis of the long-term sustainability of such faculty models. Many of these institutions rely heavily on attracting top-tier international faculty, but little is said about how they retain this talent over the long term. It could also have been worth exploring how faculty face challenges in balancing international and local academic expectations and the demands placed on them to operate in cross-cultural settings.

While the academic side of these institutions is well-covered, there is little mention of student affairs professionals' critical role play in shaping the student experience in the cross-cultural living and learning environment. Yet, other authors (e.g., Livingston et al., 2023) have demonstrated that the student affairs professionals are as crucial roles in cultivating a holistic of student development. As global institutions with diverse populations, start-up universities navigate complex cultural dynamics, and student affairs professionals seemingly have a role at the forefront of the work. The absence of consideration of their roles in cultivating global citizens limits the book's ability to critically assess the true potential of this model for long-term success in diverse contexts.

The New Global Universities offers a practical toolkit and inspiring narratives for educators, policymakers, and leaders who seek to reshape future higher education. Case studies provide concrete examples of how to foster a culture of innovation, break down disciplinary silos, and integrate technology and project-based learning into a broader liberal arts curriculum. Olin College, for example, involved students as initial venture partners to test and co-create the curriculum alongside school leaders. The practice empowered students to become active participants in designing their ideal educational experiences and fostered entrepreneurship thinking for a long-term return. By shedding light on the rise of start-up universities and their disruptive approaches, Penprase and Pickus offer a clarion call for educational reform. They provide concrete examples of integrating technology, project-based learning, and interdisciplinary collaboration into liberal arts education. However, the book's full impact will depend on how much its insights are disseminated and adopted. Collaborative efforts between governments, universities, and other stakeholders will be essential to ensure that the innovations showcased in the book benefit a wide range of students and societies. Only then we can fully realize the potential of these new models of higher education to create a more just, equitable, and sustainable future.

Reference

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